

Federal student loan repayment options

As your life changes, Aidvantage is here to help you explore options to lower, postpone, or forgive your loan payments

Source: <https://aidvantage.studentaid.gov/in-repayment/federal-options#repayment-resources>

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Repayment resources

National Student Loan Data System (NSLDS)

To view all your federal student loans and their details, log in to your account at [Federal Student Aid](#).

Beware of scams!

Borrowers have reported getting phone calls, emails, letters, and texts offering them relief from federal student loans or warning them that student loan forgiveness programs would end soon. To learn how to recognize and avoid these scams, visit the Federal Student Aid website's [Avoiding Student Loan Scams](#).

Federal student loans are made through:

- The William D. Ford Federal Direct Loan Program ("Direct Loans"), or
- The Federal Family Education Loan Program ("FFEL Program" or "FFELP")

Traditional repayment plans

Borrowers of Direct and FFELP loans generally have three repayment plans to choose from: standard, graduated, and extended.

Standard repayment plan

Standard repayment plans last up to 10 years, or up to 30 years for Consolidation Loans. They have fixed monthly payment amounts, with a minimum monthly payment of \$50. Your monthly payment amount is based on your total loan amount. The more you owe, the higher your monthly payment. You'll pay less interest over time with this plan than with other plans.

Graduated repayment plan

Graduated repayment plans offer lower payments that slowly rise to a "fully amortizing" payment. This is a payment high enough to pay off the loan by the end of the loan term. Payments are lower at first and then go up, usually every two years. They are set at an amount to ensure your loans are repaid within the remaining term. The repayment term is generally up to 10 years. It may be up to 30 years for Consolidation Loans.

Extended repayment plan

Extended repayment plans offer up to 25 years to repay your loans. Extended plans are available for most borrowers with more than \$30,000 in Direct Loans or \$30,000 in FFELP loans. You can combine an extended plan with a standard or graduated repayment plan.

Income-Driven Repayment (IDR) plans

A repayment plan based on your income and family size can help you manage your federal student loan payments. While certain eligibility conditions apply, you could potentially reduce your monthly payment to as low as \$0. Annual renewal is required however you can provide consent for the Department of Education to obtain your federal tax information directly from the IRS to automatically calculate your monthly payment annually.

For more information about student loan repayment plans, visit the Federal Student Aid website's page titled "[Repayment Plans](#)".

Types of IDR plans

Pay As You Earn Repayment Plan (PAYE)

For Direct Loans only (excluding Parent PLUS Loans and Consolidation Loans that repaid Parent PLUS Loans).

Income-Based Repayment Plan (IBR)

For Direct Loans and FFELP Loans (excluding Parent PLUS Loans and Consolidation Loans that repaid Parent PLUS Loans).

Income-Contingent Repayment Plan (ICR)

For Direct Loans only. Parent PLUS Loans may be eligible if they are consolidated into a Direct Consolidation Loan based on an application received on or after July 1, 2006.

[Visit the Federal Student Aid website](#) to review qualifications and requirements for each repayment plan option.

Income-sensitive for FFELP loans only

Although not part of the IDR program, the Income-Sensitive Repayment (ISR) option is for customers with eligible FFELP Loans. To find out if you qualify, [log in to your account](#). Choose “Help me select a repayment plan that’s right for me” and follow the prompts. If eligible, you can apply online or download the form.

IDR Annual Renewal

If you’re repaying federal student loans in an IDR plan, you need to recertify your plan each year. Recertification is around the same time of the year that you started repayment under your IDR plan. You’ll need to provide updated proof of income and certify your family size. We recommend providing consent for the Department of Education to obtain your federal tax information directly from the IRS; this will enable your plan to be renewed automatically each year. Otherwise, it’s important for you to provide the required information by the deadline.

[Renew your IDR at StudentAid.gov](#)

Direct loan consolidation

Federal loan consolidation can help borrowers combine their eligible federal student loans into one Direct Consolidation Loan. Before you consolidate, be sure you understand and carefully consider all factors.

If you have a FFELP Loan, consolidation into the Direct Loan program may let you take advantage of repayment plans or forgiveness options created only for Direct Loans.

- [Read about whether loan consolidation may be right for you](#). Be sure to first compare the advantages and disadvantages.
- If you consolidate while on active duty, you may lose benefits under the [Service Members Civil Relief Act \(SCRA\)](#).
- FFELP Loans and/or Perkins Loans may become eligible [for Public Service Loan Forgiveness](#) (PSLF) if you consolidate them into Direct Consolidation Loan. Before you consolidate, we recommend you evaluate how the qualifying payments made on the loans that would be included in your consolidation loan will be credited to your consolidation loan. For more information about which loans qualify for Public Service Loan Forgiveness, visit the [Eligible Loans](#) section on the Federal Student Aid website.

Adding other loans to a Consolidation Loan

If you are within 180 days after the date we paid off the first loans you are consolidating, you may use the form at the link below to add eligible federal loans to your existing Direct Consolidation Loan. After 180 days, you will need to apply for a new Direct Consolidation Loan.

[Apply to consolidate your loans at StudentAid.gov](#)

Payment postponement

Deferment

Deferment is a period when you postpone making payments on your loan. During most deferments, you do not pay accrued interest on Subsidized Loans. But you usually do have to pay interest that accrues on your Unsubsidized Loans.

For more information about which loans qualify for Public Service Loan Forgiveness, visit the [Get Temporary Relief](#) page.

Cancer treatment

If you're getting treatment for cancer, you may qualify for deferment.

Economic hardship

If you can't afford your student loan payments due to economic hardship or serving in the Peace Corps, you may qualify for up to three years of deferment.

Education-related

If you're enrolled at an eligible school at least half time or are in a graduate fellowship program, you qualify for deferment. A Parent PLUS Loan may also be eligible if the student is enrolled in school at least half time. There is also a deferment for Health Education Assistance Loan (HEAL) borrowers.

Military service and post-active duty

If you're an eligible service member serving active duty during a war, military operation, or national emergency, you can postpone federal loan payments.

If you recently served active duty in connection with a war, military operation, or national emergency, you may qualify to postpone federal loan payments for the 13-month period after that service ends or until you return to college or career school at least half time, whichever is earlier.

[Learn more about military benefits](#)

Rehabilitation training program

If you're enrolled in an approved rehabilitation training program for the disabled, you may qualify for deferment.

Unemployment

If you're unemployed or working less than 30 hours per week and seeking full-time employment, you may qualify for up to three years of deferment.

Loans received before 1993

If you received loans before July 1, 1993, you may qualify for added deferments. Or, your deferment choices may be different from those listed above.

[Log in to request a deferment.](#)

Forbearance

Forbearance is a period when your monthly loan payments are temporarily stopped or reduced. Payments are postponed, but interest will accrue during the forbearance period. Prior to July 1, 2023, unpaid interest may have been capitalized (added to the unpaid principal balance) which may have resulted in an increase of your total loan cost.

Note: The use of forbearance may cause the loss of borrower benefits such as repayment incentives that can lower your interest rate.

For more information about forbearance and temporary relief options, visit the Federal Student Aid website's [Get Temporary Relief](#) page.

[Learn more about capitalized interest](#)

General Forbearance

If you're having trouble making student loan payments because of economic difficulties, change in employment, medical expenses, and other situations, you may qualify. Be sure to review all other deferment options you may qualify for.

Mandatory Forbearance

If you're in medical or dental internship or residency, on National Guard active duty, AmeriCorps, or performing service that qualifies you for a partial repayment under the Department of Defense Student Loan Repayment Program, you may qualify.

Student Loan Debt Burden Forbearance

Depending on your total student loan debt and your income, you may qualify. Be sure to explore other options. You may qualify for deferment or for IDR plans.

Teacher Loan Forgiveness Forbearance

You may be eligible to postpone federal student loan payments while you're performing qualifying teaching service to earn Teacher Loan Forgiveness. If you teach full time for five complete and consecutive academic years in a low-income elementary school, secondary school, or educational service agency, you may be eligible for forgiveness of up to \$5,000 (or up to \$17,500 if you meet the criteria of a highly qualified teacher) on your Direct or FFELP loans.

Loan forgiveness, cancellation, and discharge

In certain cases, you can have your federal student loan forgiven, cancelled, or discharged. Find out whether you qualify due to your job or other circumstances.

From the January 1, 2021 tax year through the January 1, 2025 tax year, all discharge or forgiveness of any federal loan balances are not federally taxable.

Consult a tax advisor about how any loan forgiveness, cancellation, or discharge will affect your income taxes.

Teacher Loan Forgiveness

If you teach full time for five complete and consecutive academic years in a low-income elementary school, low-income secondary school, or educational service agency, you may qualify for forgiveness of up to \$5,000 (or up to \$17,500 if you meet the criteria of a highly qualified teacher) on your Direct Loans or FFELP loans.

Public Service Loan Forgiveness (PSLF)

If you're employed by a government or not-for-profit organization, you might be eligible for the Public Service Loan Forgiveness (PSLF) Program. The PSLF Program forgives the remaining balance of your eligible Direct Loans

- after you've made the equivalent of 120 qualifying monthly payments under an accepted repayment plan, and
- while working full time for an eligible employer.

To learn more about Public Service Loan Forgiveness (PSLF) and Temporary Expanded Public Service Loan Forgiveness (TEPSLF), visit the Federal Student Aid website's [Public Service Loan Forgiveness](#).

To be considered for PSLF, you only need to submit a PSLF form. The easiest way to do this is by using the [PSLF Help Tool](#). The PSLF Help Tool allows you to:

- use the [PSLF Employer Search](#) to see if your employer qualifies for PSLF,
- request that your employer's PSLF Program eligibility be reviewed if not already in the database,
- prepare and sign your PSLF form, and electronically request certification and signature from your employer, or
- generate your PSLF form for manual signature and submission if electronic submission is not possible.

You can also access the Public Service Loan Forgiveness (PSLF) form through the Federal Student Aid website's [Forms Library](#).

Payment count adjustments toward IDR and PSLF Programs

For the most current information about the payment count adjustment for student loans, visit the Federal Student Aid website's [Payment Count Adjustment](#).

Total and Permanent Disability (TPD) discharge

If you're totally and permanently disabled, you may qualify for a TPD discharge of your federal student loans. If you get a TPD discharge, you will no longer be required to repay your loans. Before your federal student loans can be discharged, you must provide information to Federal Student Aid to show that you're totally and permanently disabled.

You can show you're totally and permanently disabled in any of these ways:

- If you're a veteran, submit proof from the Department of Veterans Affairs showing that you were found unemployable due to a service-connected disability.
- If you're getting Social Security Disability Insurance (SSDI) or Supplemental Security Income (SSI) benefits.
- If your physician certifies that you're totally and permanently disabled.

Each option has specific requirements for the supporting proof you must submit with your TPD discharge application.

Discharge due to death

Federal student loans may be discharged due to the death of the borrower or the student for whom a PLUS loan was obtained. Proof of death is required.